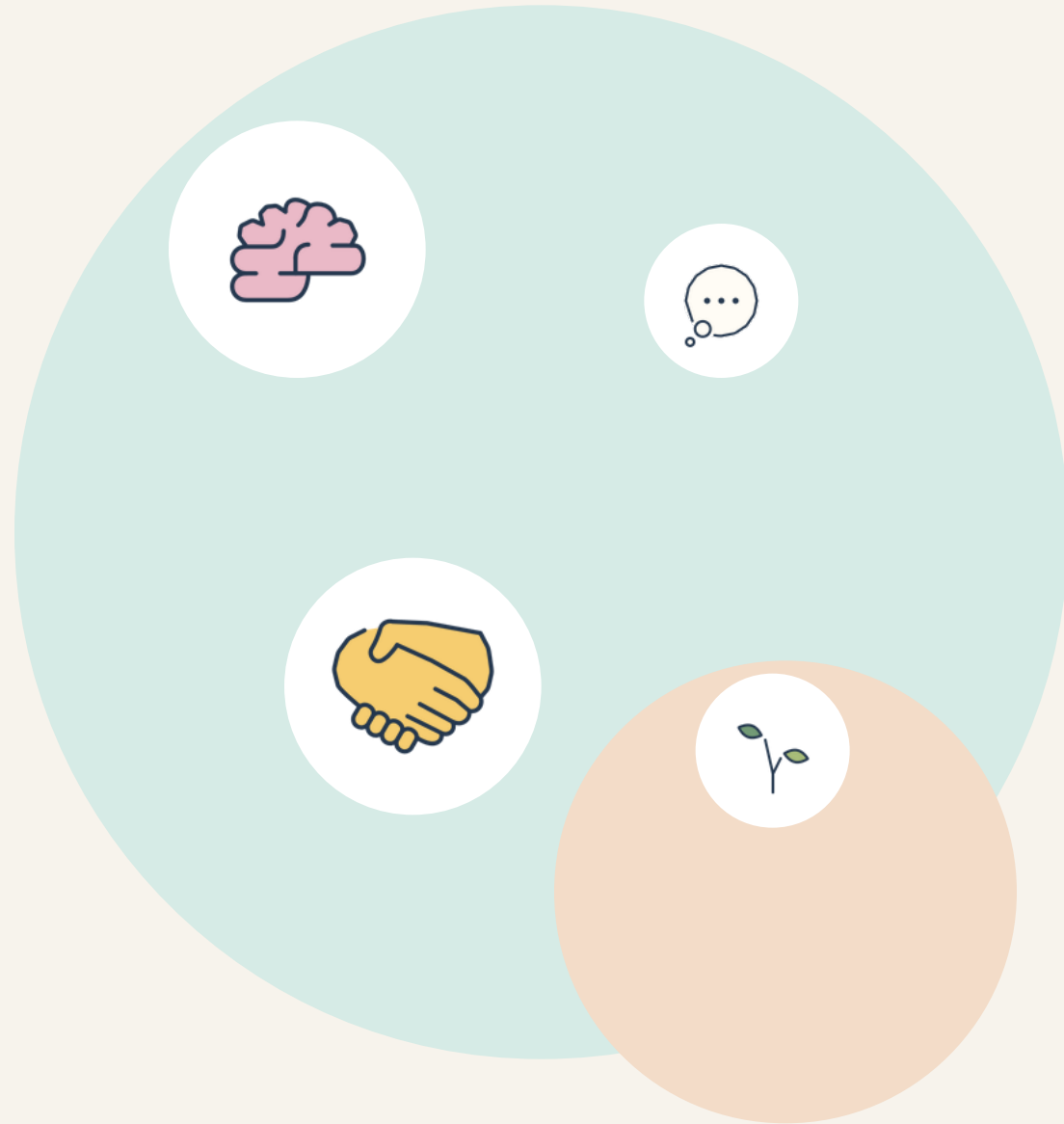


A GUIDE FOR FAMILIES, EDUCATORS AND ADULTS

Who Helps? Therapists for Autism & ADHD

The professionals, what each one does, and how they work together.



Why this matters

1 in 31

U.S. 8-year-olds identified as autistic

11.4%

of U.S. children aged 3–17 have ever been diagnosed with ADHD

Sources: CDC Autism and Developmental Disabilities Monitoring Network (2022 data, published 2025); CDC analysis of the 2022 National Survey of Children's Health.



KEY IDEA

Autism and ADHD are differences in how a brain is wired, not problems to erase.

The best therapy builds skills, comfort and independence while respecting who the person is.

The core therapy team



Occupational therapist (OT)

Sensory regulation, motor skills, routines and self-care.



Speech-language pathologist

Understanding, expression, social communication and AAC.



Psychologist

Diagnostic assessment, therapy for anxiety and mood, parent coaching.



Behavior analyst (BCBA)

Skill-building plans; choose providers who are play-based and consent-led.

Others who often help



Developmental pediatrician or psychiatrist

Diagnosis, medical care and medication for ADHD or anxiety.



Counselor or social worker

Talk therapy, family support and help finding services.



ADHD or executive-function coach

Planning, time and organization skills for teens and adults.



Physical therapist

Strength, balance and coordination when motor skills are a challenge.

How care usually unfolds



What good care looks like



Look for

- Builds on strengths and interests
- Respects every way of communicating
- Asks for assent and reads distress
- Treats the family as partners



Be cautious of

- Promises of a cure or recovery
- Ignoring signs of distress
- One program for every child
- No clear goals or progress data

Key takeaways

- 1 Support is a team effort: each discipline covers different needs.
- 2 Start with a screening or evaluation, then set shared goals.
- 3 Choose affirming providers who respect the person and the family.

This overview is educational and does not replace advice from a qualified clinician.